Project: Worked examples
Title: Motor and actuator sizing
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1. Scope and method

Torque, speed and power a motor needs to move a load through a mechanism on a point-to-point cycle: the load reflected to the motor shaft, the acceleration from the motion profile, peak torque during acceleration, RMS torque over the cycle (thermal duty), peak speed, inertia ratio, and a check of a candidate motor's rated and peak torque and speed with a safety margin. A rotary load that runs continuously (a pump, a fan) is sized instead from its steady torque and speed and a run-up time.

WHAT IT CALCULATES	RELATION
Motor-to-load ratio of a linear mechanism, in metres per motor radian	$k = p/(2\pi\, i)$ (screw); $D/(2\, i)$ (belt); $D_p/(2\, i)$ (rack)
Load inertia reflected to the motor through a linear mechanism	$J_{refl} = m\, k^2/\eta$
Load torque at the motor through a linear mechanism	$T_{load} = F\, k/\eta$, with $F = m\, g\, (\sin\theta + \mu\cos\theta) + F_p$
Reflected inertia and torque of a rotary load through a gearbox	$J_{refl} = J_L/(i^2\, \eta)$; $T_{load} = T_L/(i\, \eta)$
Move profile, trapezoidal 1/3–1/3–1/3 (adjustable)	$v_{pk} = s/(t_{move} - t_{acc})$; $a = v_{pk}/t_{acc}$
Move profile, S-curve (sine acceleration, same peak speed)	$a_{pk} = (\pi/2)\, a_{trap}$
Torque to accelerate the total inertia, and the peak torque	$T_{acc} = J_{total}\, \alpha$; $T_{pk} = T_{acc} + T_{load}$; deceleration $T_{dec} = -T_{acc} + T_{load}$; the peak check is on the larger magnitude, $SF \cdot \max(\lvert T_{pk}\rvert, \lvert T_{dec}\rvert) \le T_{peak}$, and the braking power is $P_{brake} = \max(0, -T_{dec} \cdot \omega_{pk})$
Design torque for a coupling or any part downstream that must carry what the drive can deliver, on the basis the owner chooses (T_{basis})	the load peak $T_{design} = \max(\lvert T_{pk}\rvert, \lvert T_{dec}\rvert)$ (default; T_{pk} alone in continuous duty, where there is no deceleration), the motor peak $T_{design} = T_{peak}$, a service factor on the rated torque $T_{design} = SF_c \cdot T_{rated}$, or a protective limit $T_{design} = T_{lim}$ (a torque limiter or a drive setting)
Holding torque in the dwell of a linear mechanism that is not held by a brake	$T_{hold} = m\, g \sin\theta \cdot k$ (efficiency not credited: it is a torque to stand still); it is part of the RMS torque for the whole dwell
Alternating torque amplitude of a point-to-point cycle about T_{load}, for a shaft's fatigue	$T_{alt} = (T_{pk} - T_{dec})/2$ (0 in continuous duty). Torque behind the ratio on the output shaft of a rotary mechanism: $T_{out} = T \cdot i \cdot \eta$ (mean, alternating and peak), $n_{out} = n_{pk}/i$. Peak axial thrust of a ball screw on its support bearings: $F_{ax,pk} = F_{load} + m\, a_{pk}$ (0 for other mechanisms)
RMS (thermal) torque over the whole cycle, dwell included	$T_{rms} = \sqrt{(\Sigma\, T_i^2\, t_i / t_{cycle})}$, the dwell at T_{hold}

WHAT IT CALCULATES	RELATION
RMS mechanical power over the cycle, the thermal-equivalent continuous power a supply sees (regeneration counts as power; the instantaneous peak P_{pk} is not a continuous demand), trapezoidal profile	$P_{rms} = \omega_{pk} \sqrt{\{[t_{acc} \cdot (2/3)(T_{load}^2 + T_{acc}^2) + T_{load}^2 t_{const}]/t_{cycle}\}}$; for the S-curve the acceleration term becomes $t_{acc} \cdot [(3/4)\ T_{load}^2 + (5/16)\ T_{acc}^2]$
Continuous rotary duty (a pump or fan), speed at the motor	$\omega = 2\pi\ n_L\ i/60$; $n_{pk} = n_L\ i$
Continuous rotary duty, load torque and RMS torque	$T_{load} = T_L/(i\ \eta)$; $T_{rms} = T_{load}$
Peak torque during the run-up, with full load throughout (conservative)	$T_{pk} = J_{total}\ \omega/t_{start} + T_{load}$
Continuous power	$P_{cont} = T_{load}\ \omega$; $P_{rms} = P_{cont}$; continuous duty needs the steady load torque T_L (blank or zero is refused: it would size the motor for no load)
Rated shaft power of the candidate motor, from its rated torque and its rated speed n_{rated} (not the running speed), the shaft power its supply must be sized for; without n_{rated} there is no P_{rated} and the sheet warns	$P_{rated} = T_{rated} \cdot 2\pi\ n_{rated}/60$; check $P_{cont} \le P_{rated}$, $u_{power} = P_{cont}/P_{rated}$

Basis: Load torque, inertia referred to the motor, duty cycles[1](Ch. on motor and drive selection); Reflected inertia, RMS torque, inertia ratio practice[2].

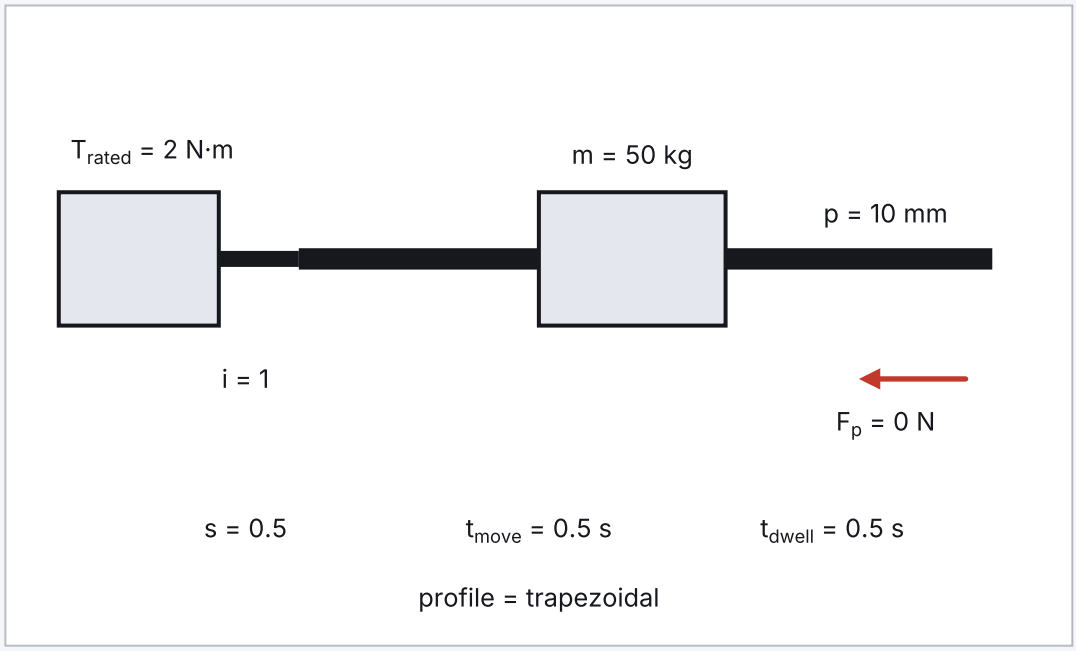


Figure 1 — A motor driving a lead or ball screw; the carriage of mass m moves along the guide. Not to scale; the labels are the inputs as entered.

2. Inputs

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
mechanism	Mechanism	`lead / ball screw`		assumption: Sizing convention.	any

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
i	Gear ratio i (motor : output, 1 = none)	1		assumption: Sizing convention.	1 … 1000
η	Mechanism efficiency (overall)	0.9		spec: Screw datasheet BS-1610: 90 %	0.3 … 1
p_{screw}	Screw lead (per revolution of the screw)	10	mm	spec: Screw datasheet BS-1610: 10 mm lead	1 … 100 mm
J_{mech}	Transmission inertia referred to the motor shaft (screw, pulleys, gearbox, coupling)	0.0001	kg·m²	spec: Screw datasheet BS-1610 + coupling: 1.0e-4 kg·m²	0 … 10 kg·m²
m	Moved mass (linear mechanisms)	50	kg	spec: Mechanical layout ML-12: carriage + gripper 50 kg	0 … 100000 kg
μ	Friction coefficient (guide / bearing)	0.1		assumption: Linear guides with seals: μ = 0.1.	0 … 1
θ	Incline from horizontal (+ moving uphill)	0	°	assumption: Sizing convention.	-90 … 90 °
F_p	Process force opposing the move (linear)	0	N	assumption: Sizing convention.	0 … 1000000 N
brake	A brake or a self-locking drive holds a linear axis during the dwell (no holding torque); unticked, a vertical or inclined axis is held by the motor	no		default	any
T_L	Constant load torque at the output (rotary; continuous duty needs it: blank or zero is refused)	0	N·m	default	0 … 100000 N·m
$duty_{mode}$	Duty (point-to-point move cycle, or continuous rotary running with a run-up)	point-to-point		default	any
profile	Motion profile	trapezoidal		assumption: Sizing convention.	any
s	Move distance (linear: m; rotary: output revolutions)	0.5		spec: Cycle specification CS-3: 0.5 m in 0.5 s, 0.5 s dwell, 1/3 ramps	0.0001 … 10000

SYMBOL	DESCRIPTION	VALUE	UNIT	SOURCE	VALID RANGE
t_{move}	Move time	0.5	s	spec: Cycle specification CS-3: 0.5 m in 0.5 s, 0.5 s dwell, 1/3 ramps	0.01 … 3600 s
f_{acc}	Acceleration (and deceleration) fraction of the move time	0.333333		spec: Cycle specification CS-3: 0.5 m in 0.5 s, 0.5 s dwell, 1/3 ramps	0.05 … 0.5
t_{dwell}	Dwell between moves	0.5	s	spec: Cycle specification CS-3: 0.5 m in 0.5 s, 0.5 s dwell, 1/3 ramps	0 … 3600 s
J_{motor}	Candidate motor rotor inertia	0.0002	kg·m²	spec: Motor datasheet SM-040: 2.0e-4 kg·m², 2.0 / 6.0 N·m, 10 000 rpm	1e-7 … 10 kg·m²
T_{rated}	Candidate motor continuous (rated) torque	2	N·m	spec: Motor datasheet SM-040: 2.0e-4 kg·m², 2.0 / 6.0 N·m, 10 000 rpm	0.01 … 100000 N·m
T_{peak}	Candidate motor peak torque	6	N·m	spec: Motor datasheet SM-040: 2.0e-4 kg·m², 2.0 / 6.0 N·m, 10 000 rpm	0.01 … 100000 N·m
T_{basis}	Design torque basis for downstream couplings (T_{design}): the load's peak (the larger of the accelerating and the braking torque, in magnitude), the motor's typed peak torque, a service factor on the rated torque, or a protective limit such as a torque limiter	Load peak (T_pk)		default	any
n_{max}	Candidate motor maximum speed	10000	rpm	spec: Motor datasheet SM-040: 2.0e-4 kg·m², 2.0 / 6.0 N·m, 10 000 rpm	10 … 100000 rpm
SF	Safety margin on torque	1.25		assumption: Sizing convention.	1 … 3
$J_{ratio,max}$	Inertia ratio limit (load : motor), warning	10		assumption: Sizing convention.	1 … 100

3. Assumptions

A1. Rigid transmission; the mechanism efficiency applies to the driving direction and is also used in the deceleration phase (conservative for peak, slightly pessimistic for RMS). (Servo-sizing practice.)

A2. The friction force is Coulomb friction on the moved mass; viscous and breakaway friction are not modelled unless included in F_p. (Load model.)
A3. Continuous duty: the load torque is constant at the stated speed and the motor accelerates the whole inertia linearly to speed in t_{start} while carrying the full load torque (conservative); the move distance, move time, acceleration fraction, dwell and profile are ignored. (Run-up idealisation for pumps and fans.)
A4. The S-curve profile has sine-shaped acceleration over the same acceleration time, so its peak acceleration is π/2 times the trapezoidal value. (Jerk-limited profile idealisation.)
A5. mechanism (Mechanism) is taken as lead / ball screw. (Sizing convention.)
A6. i (Gear ratio i (motor : output, 1 = none)) is taken as 1. (Sizing convention.)
A7. μ (Friction coefficient (guide / bearing)) is taken as 0.1. (Linear guides with seals: μ = 0.1.)
A8. θ (Incline from horizontal (+ moving uphill)) is taken as 0 °. (Sizing convention.)
A9. F_p (Process force opposing the move (linear)) is taken as 0 N. (Sizing convention.)
A10. profile (Motion profile) is taken as trapezoidal. (Sizing convention.)
A11. SF (Safety margin on torque) is taken as 1.25. (Sizing convention.)
A12. $J_{ratio,max}$ (Inertia ratio limit (load : motor), warning) is taken as 10. (Sizing convention.)

4. Working

[22] $k = p_{screw} / (2 * pi * i)$
$= 10\ mm / (2 \times \pi \times 1)$
$= 1.5915\ mm$
Travel per motor radian

[23] $F_{load} = m * 9.80665\ m/s^2 * (\sin(\theta) + \mu * \cos(\theta)) + F_p$
$= 50\ kg \times 9.80665\ m/s^2 \times (\sin(0\ deg) + 0.1 \times \cos(0\ deg)) + 0\ N$
$= 49.033\ N$
Load force along the motion (gravity, friction, process)

[25] $T_{hold} = m * 9.80665\ m/s^2 * \sin(\theta) * k$
$= 50\ kg \times 9.80665\ m/s^2 \times \sin(0\ deg) \times 1.5915\ mm$
$= 0\ N·m$
Holding torque in the dwell: the motor holds the weight of the axis (efficiency not credited)

[26] $T_{load} = F_{load} * k / \eta$
$= 49.033\ N \times 1.5915\ mm / 0.9$
$= 0.08671\ N·m$
Load torque at the motor shaft

[27] $J_{refl} = m * k^2 / \eta$
$= 50\ kg \times (1.5915\ mm)^2 / 0.9$
$= 0.00014072\ kg·m²$
Load inertia reflected to the motor shaft

[28] $v_{pk} = s * 1\ m / (t_{move} * (1 - f_{acc}))$
$= 0.5 \times 1\ m / (0.5\ s \times (1 - 0.33333))$
$= 1.5\ m/s$
Peak linear velocity (trapezoid)

[29] $a_{trap} = v_{pk} / (f_{acc} * t_{move})$
$= 1.5\ m/s / (0.33333 \times 0.5\ s)$
$= 9\ m/s²$
Trapezoidal acceleration

[30] $\omega_{pk} = v_{pk} / k$
$= 1.5\ m/s / 1.5915\ mm$
$= 942.48\ rad/s$
Peak motor speed

[32] $a_{pk} = a_{trap}$
$= 9\ m/s²$
$= 9\ m/s²$
Peak acceleration

[33] $\alpha_{pk} = a_{pk} / k$
$= 9\ m/s^2 / 1.5915\ mm$
$= 5654.9\ rad/s^2$
Peak motor angular acceleration
[34] $J_{total} = J_{motor} + J_{mech} + J_{refl}$
$= 0.0002\ kg \cdot m^2 + 0.0001\ kg \cdot m^2 + 0.00014072\ kg \cdot m^2$
$= 0.00044072\ kg \cdot m^2$
Total inertia at the motor shaft
[35] $T_{acc} = J_{total} * \alpha_{pk}$
$= 0.00044072\ kg \cdot m^2 \times 5654.9\ rad/s^2$
$= 2.4922\ N \cdot m$
Acceleration torque
[36] $T_{pk} = T_{acc} + T_{load}$
$= 2.4922\ N \cdot m + 0.08671\ N \cdot m$
$= 2.5789\ N \cdot m$
Peak torque (accelerating against the load)
[37] $T_{dec} = -T_{acc} + T_{load}$
$= -2.4922\ N \cdot m + 0.08671\ N \cdot m$
$= -2.4055\ N \cdot m$
Torque during deceleration
[38] $T_{alt} = (T_{pk} - T_{dec}) / 2$
$= (2.5789\ N \cdot m - (-2.4055\ N \cdot m)) / 2$
$= 2.4922\ N \cdot m$
Alternating torque amplitude of the cycle about T_{load}
[40] $T_{design} = \max(\text{abs}(T_{pk}), \text{abs}(T_{dec}))$
$= \max(\text{abs}(2.5789\ N \cdot m), \text{abs}(-2.4055\ N \cdot m))$
$= 2.5789\ N \cdot m$
Design torque: the load's peak torque, the larger in magnitude of the accelerating T_{pk} and the braking T_{dec} (an overhauling drive brakes harder than it accelerates)
[41] $F_{ax,pk} = F_{load} + m * a_{pk}$
$= 49.033\ N + 50\ kg \times 9\ m/s^2$
$= 499.03\ N$
Peak axial thrust on the screw's support bearings (load force plus the moved mass accelerated)
[42] $n_{pk} = \omega_{pk}$
$= 942.48\ rad/s$
$= 9000\ rpm$
Peak motor speed
[43] $P_{pk} = T_{pk} * \omega_{pk}$
$= 2.5789\ N \cdot m \times 942.48\ rad/s$
$= 2.4306\ kW$
Peak mechanical power
[44] $P_{brake} = \max(0\ N*m, -T_{dec}) * \omega_{pk}$
$= \max(0\ N*m, --2.4055\ N \cdot m) \times 942.48\ rad/s$
$= 2.2672\ kW$
Peak braking power at the start of the deceleration
[45] $t_{acc} = f_{acc} * t_{move}$
$= 0.33333 \times 0.5\ s$
$= 0.16667\ s$
Acceleration time
[46] $t_{const} = t_{move} - 2 * t_{acc}$
$= 0.5\ s - 2 \times 0.16667\ s$
$= 0.16667\ s$
Constant-velocity time

[47] $t_{cycle} = t_{move} + t_{dwell}$
$= 0.5\ s + 0.5\ s$
$= 1\ s$
Cycle time
[48] $n_{mean} = \omega_{pk} * (t_{move} - t_{acc}) / t_{cycle}$
$= 942.48\ rad/s \times (0.5\ s - 0.16667\ s) / 1\ s$
$= 3000\ rpm$
Mean motor speed over the cycle, dwell included (the travel's motor turns per cycle time)
[49] $P_{rms} = \omega_{pk} * sqrt((t_{acc} * (2 / 3) * (T_{load}^2 + T_{acc}^2) + T_{load}^2 * t_{const}) / t_{cycle})$
$= 942.48\ rad/s \times sqrt((0.16667\ s \times 2 / 3 \times ((0.08671\ N·m)^2 + (2.4922\ N·m)^2) + (0.08671\ N·m)^2 \times 0.16667\ s) / 1\ s)$
$= 0.78414\ kW$
RMS mechanical power over the cycle (thermal-equivalent continuous power)
[50] $T_{rms} = sqrt((T_{pk}^2 * t_{acc} + T_{load}^2 * t_{const} + T_{dec}^2 * t_{acc} + T_{hold}^2 * t_{dwell}) / t_{cycle})$
$= sqrt(((2.5789\ N·m)^2 \times 0.16667\ s + (0.08671\ N·m)^2 \times 0.16667\ s + (-2.4055\ N·m)^2 \times 0.16667\ N·m)^2 \times 0.5\ s) / 1\ s)$
$= 1.4402\ N·m$
RMS torque over the cycle (thermal), the dwell at the holding torque
[51] $J_{ratio} = (J_{refl} + J_{mech}) / J_{motor}$
$= (0.00014072\ kg·m^2 + 0.0001\ kg·m^2) / 0.0002\ kg·m^2$
$= 1.2036$
Inertia ratio (load : motor)
[52] $u_{peak} = SF * max(abs(T_{pk}), abs(T_{dec})) / T_{peak}$
$= 1.25 \times max(abs(2.5789\ N·m), abs(-2.4055\ N·m)) / 6\ N·m$
$= 0.53728$
Peak torque utilisation with safety margin, on the larger of the accelerating and the braking torque
[53] $u_{rms} = SF * T_{rms} / T_{rated}$
$= 1.25 \times 1.4402\ N·m / 2\ N·m$
$= 0.90012$
Continuous torque utilisation with safety margin
[54] $u_{speed} = n_{pk} / n_{max}$
$= 9000\ rpm / 10000\ rpm$
$= 0.9$
Speed utilisation
[55] $duty = T_{rms} / T_{rated}$
$= 1.4402\ N·m / 2\ N·m$
$= 0.7201$
Thermal duty (without margin)

5. Results

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
T_{load}	0.087 N·m	Load torque at motor
J_{refl}	0.00014 kg·m²	Reflected load inertia
J_{total}	0.00044 kg·m²	Total inertia
α_{pk}	5654.9 rad/s²	Motor angular acceleration
T_{acc}	2.49 N·m	Acceleration torque
T_{pk}	2.58 N·m	Peak torque
T_{dec}	-2.41 N·m	Deceleration torque
T_{rms}	1.44 N·m	RMS torque

SYMBOL	VALUE	DESCRIPTION
T_{design}	2.58 N·m	Design torque for downstream couplings
T_{hold}	0 N·m	Holding torque in the dwell
T_{alt}	2.49 N·m	Alternating torque amplitude
$F_{ax,pk}$	499.0 N	Peak axial thrust on a screw's bearings
n_{pk}	9000 rpm	Peak speed
n_{mean}	3000 rpm	Mean motor speed over the cycle
P_{pk}	2.43 kW	Peak power
P_{brake}	2.27 kW	Peak braking power
P_{rms}	0.78 kW	RMS power (continuous equivalent)
J_{ratio}	1.2036	Inertia ratio
duty	0.7201	Thermal duty
u_{peak}	0.54	Peak utilisation
u_{rms}	0.90	Continuous utilisation (governing)
u_{speed}	0.90	Speed utilisation
k	1.6 mm	Transmission constant
v_{pk}	1.50 m/s	Peak velocity
a_{pk}	9.00 m/s²	Peak acceleration

6. Checks (governing first)

RESULT	CHECK	DEMAND	CAPACITY	UTILISATION	REF
PASS	RMS torque $SF \cdot T_{rms} \le T_{rated}$	u_{rms} = 0.90	$u_{rms} \le 1$	0.90	
PASS	Speed $n_{pk} \le n_{max}$	u_{speed} = 0.90	$u_{speed} \le 1$	0.90	
PASS	Peak torque $SF \cdot \max(\lvert T_{pk} \rvert, \lvert T_{dec} \rvert) \le T_{peak}$	u_{peak} = 0.54	$u_{peak} \le 1$	0.54	

7. Applicability

WARNING records: tabulated values not taken from a reference record are J_{motor}, T_{rated}, T_{peak}, n_{max} (Candidate motor rating). Enter each as one so its source, edition and licence travel with it. [record]
WARNING n_{pk}: the peak speed is 90 % of n_{max} and T_{peak} is compared as the stall peak torque; a servo's peak torque falls toward its top speed, so check the motor's torque-speed curve at n_{pk} for T_{pk}. [peak-at-speed]
WARNING T_{dec}: the motor brakes during deceleration (negative torque); the drive must absorb the regenerated energy. [overhauling]

Defaults used (inputs left empty):
T_L: not entered, so the default of 0 N·m is used.
$duty_{mode}$: not entered, so the default of 'point-to-point' is used.
T_{basis}: not entered, so the default of 'Load peak (T_{pk})' is used.

8. Verification

Template elec.motor-sizing@1.9.0 Content hash b13348936aa53b72 Engine calc-engine/1.0.0
Known-answer cases passed 3/3 Test run 2026-10-23 12:00 UTC TempestOS 0.26.0

9. References

1. Hughes A, Drury B. Electric Motors and Drives: Fundamentals, Types and Applications. 5th ed. Newnes; 2019.
2. Kollmorgen; Parker Hannifin. Servo motor sizing guides [manufacturer technical literature].